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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

The fiddler had been tuning since the chapel bell struck eleven, and by the time Alexander reached the gate he still had not found his A. The note wavered over the yard, went sharp, and sagged back. Nobody minded it except Mr. Fenwick, who was bellowing over it at a cider cart.

"Hold you hard, the lot of you! She's in to the axle. Walk that horse on and you'll have the wheel off and the barrels in the muck, and who'll drink it then?"

The cart had come in over the soft ground by the trough and settled there with the patience of a cow in a gateway. Four estate hands stood about the back of it, considering the problem. Alexander drew off his gloves, put them in his coat pocket, and set his shoulder to the tailboard beside Davies, who anchored the tug-of-war team every autumn and smelled of the tallow he worked into the rope.

Two of the men traded a look over his head. He was taller than either, so the look had to go round him rather than past him, and he gave it no attention whatever.

"On three, Master Alexander, if you please," Davies said.

They heaved on three. The wheel came out of the mire with the sound of a boot leaving a ditch, the barrels knocked together, and Fenwick called the horse something a curate would have had to look up. Alexander stepped back with a dark crescent of the yard on his sleeve and a pleasant ache in his shoulder. Nobody thanked him. He had not expected it, and he found, on examining the matter, that he would have minded if they had.

Across the yard, under the chestnuts where the first yellow had come into the leaves, his father stood at the judging table in his shirtsleeves. Farmer Hodge faced him across it with a marrow cradled in both arms like an infant at the font.

"By weight, your Grace," Hodge said. "Allus has been by weight."

"It has been by weight," Edward agreed, "for the eleven years in which Mrs. Carrow has taken first prize." He laid two scarred fingers on the marrow's flank, as a man might lay them on a horse he meant to buy, and his face settled into the stillness Alexander had watched it hold over the county's tithe returns. "Water weighs a good deal, Mr. Hodge, and costs nothing. I put it to you. What does girth cost?"

Hodge opened his mouth and shut it again. From somewhere behind him, the Widow Carrow announced that she had heard that, thank you.

His mother had placed herself a little way off beside the cake stall, near enough to catch every word and too far for anyone to appeal to her. She caught his eye across the argument and lifted a hand to shade her face, and the thin silver lines across her palm took the sun for an instant before she lowered it. Her lips shaped, without sound, *Help him*. Then, as Edward embarked on the principle of the thing: *Don't.*

He did not. He had never once managed to argue a marrow with the gravity his father gave it, and he suspected this was a failing in him rather than in the marrow. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, fingertips tapping his thumb in turn, until Thomas Barrow came to stand at his elbow. Barrow wore his good brown coat, far too good for a morning of trestles and hurdles, and there was already straw in the buttonholes.

"Saw you at Fenwick's cart, Master Alexander. He'll tell it after as though he lifted her single-handed, mind."

"He is entirely welcome to."

Barrow smiled at his boots. He watched the judging for a while, and then, in the voice of a man remarking on a change in the wind: "Fen's looking well. Hay's all in, and the eels are running thick below the sluice. That'll feed eleven families this winter, that will, with rents what they are."

"Eleven," Alexander said.

"Counted them myself." Barrow touched his hat and went off to settle an argument over the tug-of-war rope.

Alexander had known Harrow's Fen all his life as a line in the estate book: a long strip of water-meadow under the ridge, let in parcels, which his father would not sell and had never been asked to explain. He looked toward it now. The mist lay over it soft as muslin, and through it, one after another, he found the chimneys. The Davies cottage by the sluice. The Carrows', its whitewash gone grey. He could put a name to nine of them. The other two he would have by Michaelmas, and he was a little ashamed to need until then.

He went in by the scullery passage, which was the quick way to the kitchen and ran past the butler's pantry. Along that stretch he kept his eyes on the copper moulds hung on the opposite wall, fourteen of them, fish and wheatsheaf, and went down the row as he had since boyhood. Had anyone asked, he could not have said what colour the pantry door was painted.

The kitchen met him with a wall of heat and the smell of scalded cream. Mrs. Thompson had festival ribbons looped from the beams among the hams, and was telling a scullery maid to shift herself, love, or else make herself useful. On the great deal table, in a gown of pale green silk that had no business within a mile of a range, sat his sister. She had a tart balanced on her knee and flour up one cuff, and she was swinging her foot.

"Master Alexander." Catherine inclined her head from a seated position with such exactness that it amounted to a curtsey. "You honour our humble hearth, sir. Will you take a tart, or shall I have it carried up on a salver?" She was laughing before she reached the salver. "You've mud all down your arm. Did you push something? Was it Fenwick? Mrs. Thompson says the ribbons stay up till first frost, whatever Mamma says, and I said, well, what if there isn't a frost, what if the winter simply doesn't come this year and we all..."

The sentence stopped. Her gaze had gone past his shoulder to the high window, where there was nothing but the kitchen garden wall and, above it, the pale thread of the road running south between the elms.

"And we all what?" he asked.

"Hm?" She came back to him and held out half the tart. "What was I saying?"

He took it. Behind him Mrs. Thompson dropped a pan lid and called on the Lord, and Catherine was already looking at the glass again.

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Niall had two blunted knives laid out on the bench like a surgeon's instruments before the chapel bell had finished counting two, and did not look up when Alexander came down the yard path, still smelling of trodden straw and cider must, his cravat lost somewhere between the kitchen and here.

"You're late," Niall said.

"You're early. It comes to the same thing." Alexander shrugged out of his coat and rolled his sleeves past the elbow, a habit that did nothing for his aim and everything for his nerve. Six years he had been coming down to this yard of a Saturday. Six years since a boy of sixteen had looked at a bandaged hand across a breakfast table and asked a question he had spent every year since half regretting and never once taking back. *Tomorrow, then,* Niall had said, and tomorrow had gone on arriving.

He picked up the near knife, and Niall's hand came round his wrist before his fingers had finished closing on the grip.

"Higher," Niall said. "You're throwing from the elbow again."

"I'm throwing from wherever my arm happens to be attached."

"That's generally the elbow, aye." He turned the wrist a half-inch, thumb pressed flat along the tendon, and held it there a moment longer than the correction required before he let go, the way he always did, like a man setting down a weight he wasn't yet finished carrying.

Alexander threw. The knife took the chestnut low and wide of the old scar that marked true center, and Niall made the small sound in his throat that meant he had seen it and would say nothing generous about it.

"Easy now, Alex. You're rushing it."

"Again," Alexander said, before the warmth of that could show on his face, and drew the second knife.

A wind was coming up off the stubble fields, worrying at the yew hedge and towing in a rank of cloud from the coast that had not been there an hour before. Alexander turned the blade once for balance, watching Niall rather than the target, which was its own kind of habit. Niall stood the way he always stood, weight forward, ready to be somewhere else at an instant's notice, and his eyes had gone past Alexander's shoulder to the tree line beyond the water-meadow, where nothing at all was happening. It was a small thing. A breath's worth of stillness before he blinked and came back. Alexander had spent six years learning to read it, the way another man learns to read weather in a bank of cloud, and he knew what it meant: that some part of Niall was never quite at ease, never quite here, that the man teaching him to throw a knife was also, always, listening for the sound of one thrown back.

"You're doing it again," Alexander said.

"Doing what."

"Watching the tree line as if it's about to ask you to dance."

"It hasn't asked me yet."

"Is there something out there, or do you simply find a stand of alders better company than me?"

"The alders don't talk back."

"I'm cut to the quick." He let the knife go before he'd finished the sentence, which was cheating and which Niall would tell him so, and it took the chestnut a hand's width from center, closer than the first.

"I'll manage worse before dinner." But something in his mouth had eased, not quite a smile, and his gaze came the rest of the way home to Alexander and stayed there, which was the whole of the answer he was going to get, and, for the moment, enough of one. Alexander did not ask again. He had learned that too, over six years: that Niall's watching was a country with a border he would not be shown across by asking, only by waiting, and the waiting was itself a kind of trust he did not examine too closely for fear of what he would find underneath it.

"Alex! There you are, and both of you filthy, I might have known." Catherine came down the yard path at something between a walk and a run, skirts caught up in one fist and threatening to come loose in the rising wind, and arrived a little out of breath with two small parcels of linen held out like offerings. "I have been sewing all week and nobody has thanked me for it, which I consider a great injustice, so you may both thank me now."

"Thank you," Niall said, gravely, before Alexander could open his mouth, and took the handkerchief she pressed on him with a small bow that made her laugh outright.

Alexander unfolded his. A swallow, worked in blue thread, wings spread as though caught mid-turn, the stitches close and even in a way that told him exactly how many candlelit evenings it had cost her. "For luck," she said, "since neither of you will ever go anywhere to need it, but I thought you ought to have something all the same." She said it lightly, the way she said most things she meant, and her eyes went from Alexander to Niall and back again, once, with nothing in her face he could read and everything in it he half suspected.

"Very touching," he said, to cover the suspecting. "Are you crying, Fraser?"

"Not yet." Niall was already folding the handkerchief into his waistcoat pocket, careful of the stitching, and did not look up.

Catherine only smiled, kissed her brother's cheek, and went back up toward the house with the wind pulling at her skirts and the festival noise rising faintly to meet her. Alexander folded his own handkerchief into his pocket with more attention to the corners than the object strictly required, annoyed with himself and unaccountably pleased, in roughly equal measure, and no more willing to look closely at the second than the first.

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By the time Alexander came around by the stable wall, coat slung over one shoulder and the yard's dust still ghosting the toes of his boots, the light had gone from gold to the flat gray of pewter left too long unpolished, with no sign the sun meant to leave anything better behind it before it went. Two footmen were already working along the sweep with long tapers, coaxing the lanterns alight one by one, small orange knots that the dusk swallowed almost as fast as they were struck. He had meant to be upstairs and dressed by now. He stood a moment on the gravel instead, in no hurry to trade the evening for a starched collar, and that was when the rooks went up.

They went up together, every bird on every black branch, with no single leader and no straggler left behind to call after the rest, and the sound filled the whole avenue of chestnuts at once, a tearing rush he felt in his back teeth before he properly heard it. Rooks did not do that. They complained their way into the air a dozen at a time, circled once out of habit, and settled again nearer the house before full dark, an argument they had with the evening every night of his life. Tonight the whole colony went out low over the water-meadow and did not come down.

He watched the branches a moment, empty and faintly trembling still, told himself a fox had gone through beneath them, or a gun somewhere on the Home Farm, and went on toward the house, because there was a guest arriving and his collar to see to.

He heard the wheels before he saw them: an even, unhurried roll of iron-shod wheels on gravel, no jingle of harness ornament, no horse fighting its bit, coming on at a pace that suggested the driver had never once in his life been in danger of being late. The coach that came round the gatehouse was black, lacquered to a shine that gave the lantern light back without

warming it, and where a family's arms ought to have stood on the door panel there was only more of that same depthless black. No crest. No window let into the whole of its side that Alexander could find. Two horses drew it, matched and glossy and utterly still the moment they stopped, not one of them shifting its weight or breathing out the small clouds the cold evening ought to have pulled from any beast fresh off the road. He noted it the way he noted most things that did not quite fit, filed it under well-schooled, and thought no more of it, because his father was already coming down the steps behind him with his mother and Catherine a pace behind, and there was courtesy to be done.

The man who stepped down was pale in the way of someone who spent his life indoors, fine-boned, his dark hair worn a half-inch longer than fashion allowed, in the manner of the portraits in the long gallery rather than any face met walking about the present decade. His coat was black and well cut and somehow five years behind whatever the London tailors presently claimed, the sort of thing worn by a man who had stopped attending to fashion at some particular point and never noticed the world go on without him. He bowed to Edward with an exactness that took a fraction too long, the angle held a beat past where instinct would have released it, and Alexander thought, unbidden, of a foreign dancer performing steps learned from a book rather than a partner.

"Your Grace." The voice was low, formal, and never once raised, the voice of a man who had not needed to raise it in a very long time. "Forgive the hour. I had hoped for better roads and less cloud, and got neither." He drew a letter from inside his coat, sealed in plain black wax with no device pressed into it, and held it out in both hands, the way a man presents something he considers valuable rather than mere correspondence. "A matter concerning your northern boundary, your Grace, whenever it suits you to attend to it. I am at your Grace's disposal for as long as it takes."

Edward took it, turned it once in his scarred hand, and put it away inside his own coat without breaking the seal, his face giving back exactly nothing, which Alexander had learned over two-and-twenty years to read as the loudest thing his father's face ever said. "Count Hessian." He inclined his head the correct half-inch and not a fraction more. "You'll forgive us if the hour makes for a poor welcome."

"The hour is no trouble to me at all." His eyes went past Edward, past Alexander entirely, and found Catherine on the top step, and stayed there.

It was nothing Alexander could have named to a magistrate. The man did not stare, exactly; he only looked, the way a man looks at something he has already decided belongs to him and is merely confirming the fact, and Catherine, who had never in his memory been at a loss in company, went very still under it and said nothing at all. Beside her, Amelia's hand had come to rest on her daughter's arm, light enough to pass for nothing to an eye not looking for it, and the nearest lantern caught, for a moment, the fine silver lines across his mother's palm. She was smiling. It was, Alexander thought, the exact smile she used on tenants whose rent was late and whose excuses she had already decided not to believe.

The wind that had been working the yew hedge all afternoon had gone entirely still, and had been still, he realized only now, since before the coach came through the gate. His own breath had gone shallow in his chest, the way a man breathes in a room shut up too long, and he put it down to the walk and the sudden stop and the cold coming on, because the alternative was to stand on his own front steps and admit he did not know why the evening had taken on the temperature of a cellar.

There was, in the end, no decent way to send a man with legitimate business back onto the Norfolk roads in the dark, under a sky that would give him not even starlight to travel by. Edward said as much, in fewer words than that and none of them warm. "You'll dine with us, Count Hessian. My people will see your man is looked after." Hessian bowed again, the same half-second too long.

"That is more than I looked for, your Grace, and I shan't forget that it was given." His gaze had not left Catherine, even through the bow, which should not have been possible and somehow was.

On the box the driver had not moved through the whole of it, had not so much as turned his head to watch his master descend, a thin, colorless young man whose eyes gave back the lantern light and nothing behind it. Alexander, going up the steps at last past his father's shoulder and into the hall's warm reach, found he was glad to leave him behind in the dark. The front door

stood open onto the gravel and the black coach and the empty chestnuts, spilling lamplight across the step where a stranger's boot had already crossed it, and Alexander went up to dress for dinner carrying a cold in him that no fire in the house was likely to reach.

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